

Wargame Scenario Report: Irrawaddy River Ambush, July 1944 This report provides a comprehensive wargame scenario for the July 1944 ambush by OSS-trained Kachin Rangers of Detachment 101 on Japanese troop-carrying rafts along the Irrawaddy River during the Myitkyina Campaign in northern Burma. It includes detailed information on weapons, terrain, boats, troop capacities, and other relevant factors to create an immersive and historically grounded tabletop or simulation-based wargame. The scenario is designed to reflect the guerrilla tactics of the Kachin Rangers and the defensive response of the Japanese 15th Army, based on extensive research into primary and secondary sources.

Scenario Overview Historical Context In July 1944, the Myitkyina Campaign was a pivotal effort in the China-Burma-India (CBI) Theater of World War II. The Allies, led by Lieutenant General Joseph Stilwell, aimed to capture Myitkyina to secure its airfield and disrupt Japanese control in northern Burma. The Japanese 15th Army, including elements of the 18th and 56th Divisions, was under pressure, retreating or resupplying via the Irrawaddy River. The OSS Detachment 101, leveraging the Kachin Rangers, conducted guerrilla operations to harass Japanese forces, sever supply lines, and support the Allied siege of Myitkyina. The ambush targeted Japanese troop-carrying rafts, a key evacuation and resupply method, contributing to the eventual fall of Myitkyina on August 3, 1944. **Wargame Objective**

Kachin Rangers (Allies): Ambush Japanese rafts to inflict maximum casualties, disrupt troop movements, and gather intelligence from recovered bodies. Success is measured by the number of rafts destroyed or troops eliminated within a 5-10 minute engagement, followed by a safe withdrawal. **Japanese 15th Army:** Defend the rafts, minimize losses, and return fire to suppress or repel the ambush. Success is measured by the number of rafts that survive the ambush and reach their destination.

Scenario Setup

Time: July 1944, during the monsoon season (daylight or twilight for visibility).
Location: Irrawaddy River, south of Myitkyina, northern Burma. **Duration:** 5-10 minutes of intense combat, reflecting the hit-and-run tactics of Detachment 101. **Forces:**
Kachin Rangers: 50-100 guerrillas, organized into 2-4 squads of 15-25 each, led by 1-2 OSS officers. **Japanese Troops:** 2-4 rafts, each carrying 10-20 troops (total 20-80 troops), from the 15th Army (likely 18th Division remnants).

Scale: Suitable for 1:1 skirmish wargames (e.g., Bolt Action, Chain of Command) or small-unit simulations.

Forces and Armament Kachin Rangers (OSS Detachment 101)

Composition: 50-100 Kachin Rangers, trained in guerrilla warfare, with 1-2 OSS officers for command and coordination. The Kachins were highly mobile, familiar with jungle terrain, and adept at ambushes. **Weapons:** A mix of American and British small arms, reflecting OSS supply drops. M1A1 Thompson Sub-Machinegun (60% of troops):
Caliber: .45 ACP **Range:** Effective up to 100 meters **Rate of Fire:** ~600-700 rounds/min
Role: Primary weapon for close-range ambushes, high stopping power, ideal for rapid volleys from riverbank cover.

Bren Gun (Mk I or II) (2-4 per squad): **Caliber:** .303 British **Range:** Effective up to 600 meters **Rate of Fire:** ~500 rounds/min **Role:** Suppressive fire, highly reliable in jungle conditions, used to pin down Japanese troops on rafts.

M1919 Machinegun (1-2 per 50 troops): Caliber: .30-06 Springfield Range: Effective up to 1,400 meters Rate of Fire: ~400-600 rounds/min Role: Heavy suppressive fire, positioned for maximum coverage of the river, though prone to jamming in wet conditions.

M1 Garand or M1 Carbine (20% of troops): M1 Garand: .30-06, 8-round clip, effective up to 500 meters, semi-automatic. M1 Carbine: .30 Carbine, 15-30-round magazine, effective up to 300 meters, lighter and more mobile. Role: Medium-range support, used by Rangers covering flanks or retreat routes.

United Defense UD-42 Submachine Gun (5-10% of troops): Caliber: 9×19mm Parabellum Range: Effective up to 200 meters Rate of Fire: ~700 rounds/min Role: Less common, used by select Rangers for close-range combat.

Hand Grenades (Mk 2 "Pineapple"): Quantity: 1-2 per Ranger Role: Thrown from riverbank to disrupt rafts or target clustered troops, though less effective against moving targets.

Dah (Kachin Short Sword/Machete): Role: Close-quarters combat (unlikely in this scenario) or utility for cutting through jungle.

Tactics: Set up concealed positions along the riverbank, using jungle foliage for cover. Engage rafts with coordinated volleys, prioritizing light machine guns to suppress, followed by Thompsons for rapid kills. Withdraw after 5-10 minutes to avoid Japanese counterattacks or reinforcements. Morale: High, due to Kachin loyalty, jungle expertise, and OSS training. +1 to morale checks in wargame rules for familiarity with terrain.

Japanese 15th Army (Likely 18th Division Remnants)

Composition: 20-80 troops across 2-4 rafts, likely from the 18th Division, weakened to ~3,000 men by June 1944. Troops include infantrymen, possibly with 1-2 officers per raft. Poor supply and morale due to prolonged campaign and monsoon conditions.

Weapons: Standard Japanese infantry armament, constrained by raft space. Type 38 Arisaka Rifle (60-70% of troops): Caliber: 6.5×50mm Arisaka Range: Effective up to 500 meters Rate of Fire: Bolt-action, ~10-15 rounds/min Role: Primary weapon, used for return fire, limited by raft instability and cover.

Type 99 Rifle (20-30% of troops): Caliber: 7.7×58mm Arisaka Range: Effective up to 600 meters Rate of Fire: Bolt-action, ~10-15 rounds/min Role: Similar to Type 38, with better stopping power, used by better-equipped troops.

Type 96 or Type 99 Light Machine Gun (1-2 per raft): Caliber: 7.7×58mm Arisaka Range: Effective up to 800 meters Rate of Fire: ~500 rounds/min Role: Suppressive fire, critical for countering ambush, but limited by magazine size (30 rounds) and raft movement.

Type 100 Submachine Gun (1-2 per raft, NCOs or elite troops): Caliber: 8×22mm Nambu Range: Effective up to 150 meters Rate of Fire: ~450 rounds/min Role: Close-range defense, compact for raft use, but rare due to limited production.

Type 14 Nambu Pistol (1-2 per raft, officers): Caliber: 8×22mm Nambu Range: Effective up to 50 meters Rate of Fire: Semi-automatic, ~6-8 rounds/min Role: Sidearm, minimal impact in ambush scenario.

Type 97 or Type 99 Hand Grenades (1-2 per soldier): Role: Defensive throws toward riverbank, limited by raft instability and ambush range (50-200 meters).

Tactics: Limited to reactive defense. Troops fire rifles and light machine guns from rafts, aiming to suppress riverbank positions. Grenades may be thrown if rafts are close to the bank (<50 meters). Rafts attempt to paddle to safety or beach on the opposite bank to regroup. Morale: Low, due to supply shortages, disease, and prolonged retreat. -1 to morale checks in wargame rules, with risk of panic under sustained fire.

Terrain and Environment Irrawaddy River

Width: 800-1,500 meters, averaging ~1,000 meters near Myitkyina during the July 1944 monsoon. The wide expanse exposes rafts to fire from one bank, limiting Japanese return fire effectiveness. Depth and Current: Monsoon flooding increases depth to 2-5 meters in the main channel, with strong currents (2-4 knots). Rafts move at ~2-3 knots downstream, affecting aim and maneuverability. Banks: Steep, muddy banks (1-2 meters high) covered in dense jungle foliage (bamboo, teak, vines). Provides hard cover (+2 to cover saves) for Kachin Rangers. Opposite bank may be open or partially vegetated, offering little cover if rafts beach. Visibility: Daylight or twilight, with potential for fog or rain reducing visibility to 200-500 meters (-1 to hit rolls beyond 200 meters). Jungle canopy obscures overhead air support or spotting.

Surrounding Terrain

Jungle: Dense, with visibility limited to 10-50 meters on land. Movement is difficult terrain (half speed for infantry), but Kachins ignore this penalty due to expertise. Trails: Narrow paths (1-2 meters wide) allow Kachin withdrawal, but no major roads are nearby. Japanese reinforcements (if any) arrive via river or distant trails (2-3 turns delay). Weather: Monsoon rains make ground soggy (-1 to movement rolls for non-Kachins). Constant wetness affects weapon reliability (1% chance per turn for M1919 jamming).

Tactical Implications

Kachin Advantage: Concealed positions in jungle cover allow first-strike advantage. Wide river ensures rafts are exposed for 1-2 turns before reaching cover or exiting the board. Japanese Disadvantage: Rafts offer no cover (0 cover save), and troops are prone to suppression. Limited raft maneuverability restricts tactical options.

Boats and Materials Japanese Troop-Carrying Rafts

Construction: Bamboo or logs, lashed with vines or rope, possibly reinforced with planks or barrels. Bamboo is buoyant (1 culm supports ~50 kg), and rafts are camouflaged with foliage to blend with the river. Size: 15-25 feet long, 6-10 feet wide, with larger rafts (up to 30 feet) for heavier loads. Surface area supports 500-1,000 kg, including troops and light supplies. Capacity: 10-20 troops per raft, with minimal gear (rifles, grenades, personal equipment). Larger rafts could carry up to 30, but 10-15 is most common for maneuverability. Durability: Fragile (1 hit point in wargame terms). Small arms fire can damage lashings, causing instability (50% chance of troops falling into water if hit). Grenades or sustained fire may sink a raft (2 hits). Movement: Paddled or poled, moving 2-3 knots downstream. Monsoon currents add +1 knot but reduce control (-1 to maneuver rolls). Wargame Stats: Armor: None (0 save) Hit Points: 1 (sinks on 1 hit from heavy weapons or 2 hits from small arms) Speed: 4-6 inches/turn (assuming 1 inch = 10 meters) Capacity: 10-20 models (1 model = 1 soldier)

Other Vessels (Optional)

Sampan or Dugout Canoes: If included, these carry 5-10 troops, are faster (4 knots), but equally fragile. Less likely in this scenario, as rafts are explicitly mentioned. Daihatsu-Class Landing Craft: Rare due to fuel shortages, but possible for larger troop movements. Carries 50-70 troops, armored (light cover, +1 save), but unlikely in this ambush. Not recommended for scenario fidelity.

Additional Scenario Details Game Board Setup

Board Size: 6x4 feet (tabletop) or equivalent digital map, with the river running lengthwise (4-6 inches wide, scaled to ~1,000 meters). River: Central feature, flowing from top to bottom. Mark banks with jungle terrain (scatter trees, foliage). Place 2-4 rafts at the top, spaced 6-12 inches apart. Kachin Positions: Deploy 2-4 squads in jungle along one bank, within 12 inches of the board edge. Units start hidden (require spotting check to target). Japanese Rafts: Deploy at board top, moving 4-6 inches per turn downstream. Troops are visible but have no cover. Exit Zone: Bottom board edge (Japanese objective to escape ambush).

Turn Structure

Turns: 6-10 turns, reflecting 5-10 minutes of combat (1 turn = ~1 minute). Initiative: Kachins always act first in Turn 1 (surprise). Roll for initiative in subsequent turns. Kachin Actions: Fire: Target rafts within range (Thompsons 100 meters/10 inches, Brens 600 meters/60 inches, M1919s 1,400 meters/entire board). Move: Reposition along bank or withdraw into jungle (12 inches/turn). Special: Search downed rafts for intelligence (requires 1 turn adjacent to beached raft, yields victory points).

Japanese Actions: Fire: Return fire at spotted Kachin positions (rifles 500 meters/50 inches, LMGs 800 meters/80 inches). Move: Paddle rafts downstream or attempt to beach (4-6 inches/turn, 50% chance of failure if under fire). Special: Throw grenades if within 50 meters/5 inches of bank (limited to 1-2 per soldier).

Victory Conditions

Kachin Rangers: Major Victory: Destroy/sink 75%+ of rafts or eliminate 75%+ of Japanese troops (3-4 rafts, 15-60 troops). Minor Victory: Destroy/sink 50% of rafts or eliminate 50% of troops (2 rafts, 10-40 troops). Bonus: +1 victory point per intelligence item recovered (max 2).

Japanese Troops: Major Victory: 75%+ of rafts reach the exit zone with 50%+ troops alive (3-4 rafts, 10-40 troops). Minor Victory: 50% of rafts reach the exit zone with 50%+ troops alive (2 rafts, 5-20 troops). Bonus: +1 victory point per Kachin squad suppressed or eliminated (max 2).

Special Rules

Monsoon Effects: Rain reduces visibility (-1 to hit beyond 200 meters/20 inches) and causes 1% chance per turn for M1919 jamming (roll 1 on D100). Raft Instability: Rafts hit by small arms have a 50% chance of troops falling into water (1D6 models lost per hit). Heavy weapons (Bren, M1919) sink rafts instantly. Kachin Concealment: Kachins start hidden, requiring a spotting check (6+ on D6 at 100 meters, +1 per 100 meters beyond). Japanese fire at unspotted units has -2 to hit. Japanese Morale: Low morale causes -1 to morale checks. If 50% of a raft's troops are lost, survivors must pass a morale check (7+ on D6) or surrender/panic. Intelligence Gathering: Kachins can search downed rafts (1 turn adjacent, yields 1 intelligence item). Bodies were historically searched downstream for documents.

Research Details Sources Consulted

Primary Sources: arsof-history.org: A Special Forces Model: Detachment 101 in the Myitkyina Campaign, Part I & II: Detailed accounts of Kachin Ranger tactics, weapons (M1A1 Thompson, Bren, M1919), and river ambushes. CIA: Irrawaddy Ambush: Confirms ambush on troop-carrying rafts, emphasizes Kachin guerrilla operations. history.army.mil: Merrill's Marauders: Third Mission: Myitkyina: Contextualizes Japanese retreat and raft use.

Secondary Sources: Wikipedia: Burma Campaign (1944-1945): Provides Japanese 15th Army composition, weapons, and logistical challenges. Wikipedia: OSS Detachment 101: Details Kachin Ranger training, equipment, and impact. The Irrawaddy: Memories of WWII Run Deep for KIO: Notes Kachin contributions and terrain challenges.

Hydrological Studies: Modern data on Irrawaddy River width (~500-1,800 meters in monsoon) adjusted for 1944 conditions (no dams).

Key Findings

Kachin Weapons: Confirmed use of M1A1 Thompsons, Bren guns, M1919s, M1 Garands/Carbines, and UD-42s via OSS supply drops. Grenades were carried by OSS air drop teams, suggesting possible use. Japanese Weapons: Standard infantry arms (Type 38/99 rifles, Type 96/99 LMGs, Type 100 SMGs, Nambu pistols, grenades) based on 15th Army equipment in 1944. Heavy weapons unlikely on rafts. Rafts: Bamboo or log construction, carrying 10-20 troops, confirmed by ambush descriptions and regional practices. Camouflage noted. River Width: Estimated at 800-1,500 meters based on monsoon flooding, historical accounts, and modern hydrological data. Terrain: Dense jungle, muddy banks, and monsoon conditions shaped tactics, favoring Kachin concealment and mobility. Troop Morale: Kachins had high morale due to training and terrain familiarity; Japanese morale was low due to disease, starvation, and retreat.

Research Gaps

Exact Ambush Location: No precise coordinates for the ambush site, assumed to be south of Myitkyina along a broad river section. Japanese Unit Details: Likely 18th Division remnants, but specific battalion or company not identified. Grenade Use by Kachins: OSS air drop teams carried grenades, but ground use in this ambush is unconfirmed. Raft Specifications: General size and capacity estimated from regional practices; no detailed Japanese military raft designs documented.

Wargame Notes

Balance: The scenario favors the Kachin Rangers due to their ambush advantage, terrain cover, and superior firepower. To balance, consider adding a Japanese reinforcement raft (arrives Turn 3-4) or allowing one raft to carry a Type 92 HMG (rare but possible). Scalability: For larger games, increase Kachin squads (up to 200, as per Mudrinich's group) or rafts (up to 6). For smaller games, use 1-2 rafts and 25-50 Kachins. Narrative Elements: Incorporate Kachin intelligence gathering (searching bodies) and Japanese desperation (low morale, potential surrender). Add flavor with OSS officer leadership or Kachin cultural traits (e.g., collecting enemy ears, though optional). Terrain Modeling: Use green felt or scatter terrain for jungle, blue cloth for the river, and brown strips for muddy banks. Raft models can be crafted from balsa wood or cardstock with foliage scatter for camouflage.

Conclusion This wargame scenario recreates the July 1944 Irrawaddy River ambush with historical fidelity, capturing the asymmetry of Kachin guerrilla tactics against

vulnerable Japanese rafts. The Kachin Rangers' use of Thompsons, Brens, and M1919s, combined with jungle cover and surprise, gives them a tactical edge, while the Japanese struggle with rifles, LMGs, and low morale on fragile rafts. The Irrawaddy's 800-1,500-meter width, monsoon conditions, and dense terrain shape the engagement, creating a dynamic and immersive experience. Victory hinges on the Kachins' ability to maximize casualties in a brief window and the Japanese ability to survive and escape. This scenario is ideal for skirmish wargames, offering replayability through variable raft numbers, weather effects, and tactical choices. For further customization, contact the scenario designer with specific rulesets (e.g., Bolt Action, Flames of War) or desired modifications (e.g., adding air support, adjusting force sizes). Happy wargaming!